



SCAN TO
WATCH

THE 'FOSBURY FLOP' IN MEXICO TRANSFORMED THE HIGH JUMP FOREVER

Randhir Singh

Every four years, the best athletes gather for this global event. There isn't a sporting spectacle more incredible than the Olympics. I have had the privilege of participating in five Olympic Games as a shooter. In 1964, I went as a reserve. Then, they took me in '68, '72, '76, '80 and '84.

You'll be amazed that I've been associated with the Olympic Council of Asia since 1991. We have run 27 Asian Games, including the summer, winter, beach games, Youth Games, and Asian martial arts indoor games. So, we saw a lot of games and a lot of sports.

It'd be interesting to know that at the 1951 Asian Games, I was there for the opening ceremony and saw some events. I was five years old. And then, I went to Helsinki with my father for the Olympic Games in 1952. I shot in the pre-Olympics in '63. In fact, on the 18th (October), I turned 18 at the 18th Olympic Games (1964).

I had a great coach and mentor in Karni Singh. It was a pleasure shooting with him. We shot from 63 to 82 at the Asian Games, when our team picked up a silver in the Delhi games.

Returning to the 1968 Mexico Olympics, the world was going through a crisis. There was a lot of strife in Mexico. People were worried about whether the Games might happen or not. But when we went there, I thought we saw a great Olympics. We had so much fun. People were casual, loving, and very helpful. Some of the infrastructure was not ready. It was just about getting ready. But they managed to complete everything on time.

Since its inception, the Olympics has witnessed some unbelievable feats. We also saw fantastic performances in Mexico, like Bob Beamon's (long jump). I was there to watch him come up with that grand jump. Beamon almost jumped out of the pit. They didn't know at the venue that this had happened because the long jump pit was on one side of the stadium. The crowd was stunned when it appeared on the screen. He had cleared 8.90m, and his record stood for 23 years before Mike Powell (8.95m) broke it in 1991.

How can one forget the Dick Fosbury flop? His back-first jump was the most fantastic thing one had seen. I did a bit of high jump

when I was in school, but to see somebody run up with this twisted body and go over the bar the other way around, I thought it was incredible. I have gotten to know Beamon well. I have met him and Fosbury quite a few times after the Mexico Olympics. We met as administrators. The boxing gold by George Foreman also stood out.

We were provided with a delightful Games village. It was a very welcoming place with people gathered around and athletes singing in every corner of the stadium. We also had a cultural centre there, which was a lot of fun. The food was excellent, and I found that Mexican cuisine is quite similar to Indian food, so we could enjoy it quite a lot. Overall, it was a fun experience. While I may have discovered some organizational loopholes, I didn't encounter any issues with the event itself. Playing in the Olympic Games was truly exhilarating. In the evenings, everyone would gather together and make new friends.

For an Indian, the medal that matters at the Olympics is hockey. The rich heritage that Indian hockey had acquired through the gold medals in '28, '32, '36, '48, '52, '56 and '64 was a matter of great pride. Losing the gold to Pakistan in '60 hurt the game in India, but there were high hopes we would win the gold in Mexico. Sadly, it did not